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FREE CHECKLIST · 2026 EDITION

Your Ecommerce Tools Checklist: The Essential Starter Pack (Free & Freemium)

Launch your online store without breaking the bank. Use our simple ecommerce tools checklist to find the best free and freemium platforms for building, managing, and growing your business.



6 pages · PDF

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What's inside

3 short sections. Read it in order, or jump to the part you need today.

01 Your Website & Selling Foundation

02 Product Sourcing & Inventory Management

03 Marketing & Getting Your First Sales

With so much information out there, it's easy to feel overwhelmed and not know where to begin your online store journey. You don't need a huge budget or technical skills to get started, you just need the right toolkit.

This article is your straightforward, beginner-friendly ecommerce tools checklist. We've curated a list of essential, high-quality tools that are either free to start or offer powerful freemium plans. Let's break down your launch into simple, actionable steps.

01 Your Website & Selling Foundation

First, you need a digital storefront. This is where you'll list your products and process orders. The goal here is to choose a platform that is easy to use without requiring you to code.

Your top priority is an ecommerce platform. These are all-in-one services that let you build your website, add products, and accept payments.

- Shopify: The industry leader for a reason. Its intuitive drag-and-drop builder makes it easy to create a professional-looking store. You can start with a free trial and enjoy a $1/month plan for 3 months, followed by a paid plan, but it's worth mentioning for its unmatched ease-of-use.
- WooCommerce: A free, open-source plugin that turns your WordPress website into a fully-featured store. It's incredibly powerful and flexible, but requires you to have a WordPress site set up (which involves purchasing web hosting).
- Ecwid: A fantastic "start anywhere" option. Ecwid lets you add a shopping cart to your existing website, Facebook page, or even Instagram. Its starter plan is perfect for testing the waters with up to 5 products and over 70 site templates to choose from.

Actionable Step: For the absolute beginner who wants the simplest path, start with Shopify's free trial or Ecwid's $5 starter plan.

02 Product Sourcing & Inventory Management

Now, let's get your products ready. Whether you're making items yourself, buying wholesale, or using a print-on-demand model, you need a system to keep track of everything.

You need a simple way to manage your stock levels to avoid overselling. This is a critical part of any ecommerce tools checklist.

- Google Sheets / Excel: Don't underestimate the power of a well-organized spreadsheet! It's a completely free and flexible way to list your products, track inventory counts, and calculate costs. This is a great place to start.
- Printful: If you're interested in print-on-demand (creating t-shirts, mugs, etc., only after an order is placed), Printful is a top choice. It integrates seamlessly with platforms like Shopify and

WooCommerce, and you don't pay anything until you make a sale.

- Basic Platform Tools: Before investing in a separate app, use the built-in inventory management features inside your ecommerce platform. Shopify and WooCommerce both have solid basic systems to get you started. There are also some free to low cost beginner-friendly inventory management apps that you can consider.

Actionable Step: Begin by listing your first 5–10 products in a simple Google Sheet with columns for Product Name, Cost, Price, and Quantity.

03 Marketing & Getting Your First Sales

Your store is live and stocked, now you need customers! The goal here is to get visible without a large advertising budget.

You don't need a complex marketing strategy on day one. Focus on the fundamentals of attracting an audience.

- Mailchimp: The gold standard for email marketing. Its free plan allows you to collect subscriber emails from your store and send up to 2,500 emails per month to 500 contacts. Building an email list is one of the most valuable ecommerce business assets you can have.
- Canva: An incredibly easy-to-use graphic design tool. Create professional-looking social media posts, banners for your store, and email graphics without any design experience. The free version is packed with templates.
- Facebook & Instagram Shops: If your target audience is on social media, use these free built-in tools. They let you create a native shopping experience directly on your social profiles, turning browsing into buying.

Actionable Step: Create a free Canva account and design a simple graphic to announce your store's launch on social media.

Your Simple Ecommerce Tools Checklist

Use this as a quick reference to ensure you have the basics covered:

- Store Platform: Signed up for Shopify, WooCommerce, or Ecwid.
- Product List: Created a simple inventory spreadsheet.
- Payment Processor: Enabled Stripe/PayPal in your store.
- Email Marketing: Set up a Mailchimp account and added a signup form to your store.
- Design Tool: Created a Canva account for marketing graphics.

- Inventory Management Tools: Set up the in-built options available on your store platform or signed up for an external provider.

Remember, the goal is to start simple. You can always upgrade and add more sophisticated tools as your business grows. The most important step is to begin.

Feeling more confident but want a guided path? At Shopinbos, we help you navigate these first steps without the confusion. Explore our step-by-step guides and find the perfect tools for your unique vision.

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Ready to make your first sale?

Rex builds your store with you in 5 minutes. Take card, transfer and pay on delivery, book riders, and let Peggy answer customers on WhatsApp.

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